

Zearn's Approach to English Learner Support for Independent Digital Lessons

Introduction

Language learners of all levels can and should engage with grade-level math content, scaffolded with the appropriate amount of linguistic support. Zearn Math provides English learners (ELs) the opportunity to engage in math activities using multiple learning modalities with embedded scaffolded supports.

Approach

Supported by [research](#), Zearn Math fosters the side-by-side development of math understanding and language competence along with repeated opportunities to learn math across all language domains. Zearn Math scaffolds instruction for English learners to support sense-making through Independent Digital Lessons (IDL) where students observe on-screen teachers and students model math and math language. While these features of Zearn Math support all students in building a deep understanding of grade-level math, they are particularly critical for meeting the needs of English learners, who are simultaneously learning math and acquiring language.

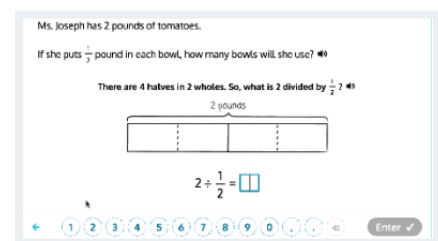
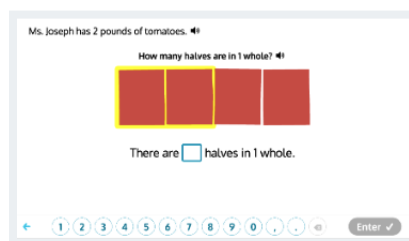
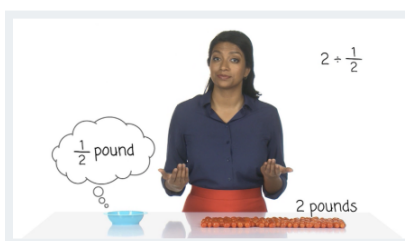
Teachers with a Zearn School Account can enable Spanish for Independent Digital Lessons.

Features of Zearn Math that support English learners:



Concrete to pictorial to abstract (CPA)

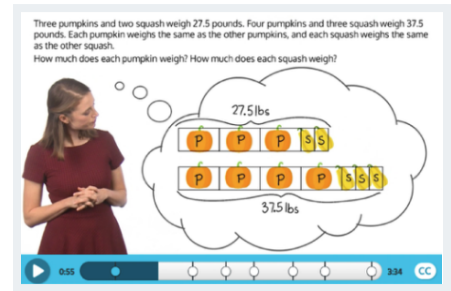
As students learn new concepts and make sense of math, they move seamlessly from concrete materials to pictorial representations to abstract symbols. This progression creates an on-ramp into learning without the heavy lift of language for English learners.





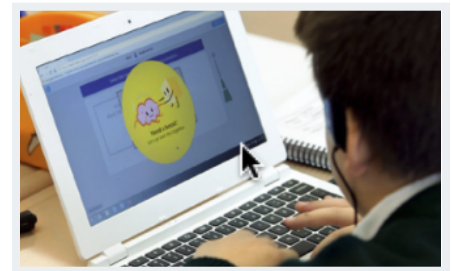
Visualization

Visual models intentionally align to how students naturally think about and represent math concepts. Visualizations allow English learners to overcome language barriers and leverage their intuitive thinking to develop a deeper understanding of mathematics.



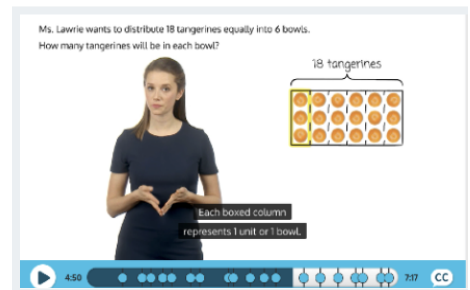
In-the-moment scaffolding

When students make a mistake in their Guided Practice and Independent Practice, they receive just-in-time support that breaks down the question into smaller steps with different visuals and more supportive prompts. This just-in-time support addresses misconceptions and then allows English learners multiple opportunities to try again.



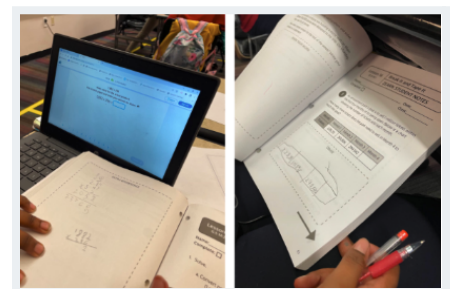
Embedded language support

Every lesson incorporates explicit teaching of important mathematical terminology, ensuring it is introduced and reinforced regularly. Additionally, each lesson integrates accessibility features such as text-to-speech, pause and rewind, and closed captioning which offers language assistance for English learners.



Paper-to-pencil transfer

Paper-and-pencil transfer from digital lessons provide English learners with safe opportunities to deepen and retain their learning. Students are exposed to words, expressions and sentences, as they label diagrams, write sentences, and explain their solutions.





AVAILABLE FOR 2026-27

Spanish-Translated Digital Content

Teachers with Zearn School Accounts can give students the option to complete Independent Digital Lessons in Spanish. When teachers enable the Spanish language setting, students will be able to switch seamlessly between learning in English and Spanish, expanding students' access to rigorous, grade-level math learning on Zearn through a flexible design that supports learning in Spanish while reinforcing academic language in English and strengthening cross-linguistic connections. Click here for the [Navigation Guide](#).

